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Business Psychology: Workplace Conflict

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Despite its prevalence in sitcoms, conflict in the workplace is no laughing matter. Business etiquette requires the professionally minded conduct themselves with civility. This is a breeze when things are going well, but how do we approach necessary confrontation in a polite, respectful and productive manner?

Let's discuss.

A confrontation results from a breakdown in communication, a disagreement or opposing goals. And we can all be adult enough to admit that those catalysts for conflict happen often in the business world.

The standard mantra is to keep quiet and just do your work. This may seem like great advice for those looking to beat the clock while attempting to forget those festering feelings inside. This short-sighted attempt to deflect may ultimately do more harm than good.

Avoiding conflict when confrontation is necessary can poison your business relationships, and may harm your reputation and your career. In the article "[5 Keys to Dealing with Workplace Conflict](#)," Forbes contributor Mike Myatt explains, "Unresolved conflict often results in loss of productivity, the stifling of creativity, and the creation of barriers to cooperation and collaboration."

So what is a professionally minded executive to do?

First, we need to understand that avoiding conflict is not always the most ethical course of action.

The Ethics of Conflict vs Avoidance



Keeping quiet in the workplace functions as an ethical solution so long as you don't harbor resentment for the unresolved situation.

Let's say that management issues a decision that affects you. You might not agree with it, but you understand your role in the organization. No harm, no foul. If you were in charge you might have made a different decision, but a strong argument is not founded on hypotheticals. Concluding with no lingering emotional impact and a clear path forward is how most disagreements in the workplace end.

This is a perfectly ethical way to deal with a disagreement that doesn't result in a confrontation.

However, there is an unethical flip side to this stance. Consider the possible scenario of keeping quiet when you have a firm disagreement on something you're directly involved in, perhaps even implicated in. Perhaps a co-worker incorrectly pointed out something you did as causing a problem in the workflow. These moments when you make the decision to stay quiet may result in a lingering emotional compulsion to absolve implicated responsibility.

If you keep quiet while seething about unfair treatment, you may want to rethink your strategy. Think of it like a covered pot of boiling water; you need to let the steam vent. If you don't, the results could be explosive. Keeping this bottled up can only result in increasingly negative thoughts and actions, and will poison your workplace relationships. Harboring resentment and keeping quiet about it just allows pressure to build. All the while, the person you have these feelings toward may be unaware of it.



Allowing time to pass while your unresolved anger grows would be considered an unethical avoidance of conflict. With every passing minute your mind is poisoned by that increase in pressure from holding in your feelings.

Unfortunately, as that pressure grows it becomes increasingly difficult to confront another in an ethical manner. Worse still, approaching someone like an overtaxed boiler releasing pent up steam might only confuse the other person. If the infraction seemed minor to the other party, he may have no idea why you are angry. Hurling accusations like, “You know what you did!” might be received with a shrug, which might make the episode worse still.

Perhaps modern day reliance on digital communication has forced face-to-face confrontation to become sparse and stilted. Isolation doesn’t improve a festering feeling of being wronged. Not approaching the disagreement with tact and respect just forces the problem under the rug and will only manifest itself as a deeper and more aggressive problem later.

The Receiving End

Since the majority of this article has been describing the inner struggle of those avoiding conflict, we must turn our attention to the other side of the confrontation: the confronted.

We are an emotional species. We understand right from wrong and do our best to follow the rules. However, when someone has a grievance, there are times when conflict is unavoidable.

There will be times in your life where you’ve wronged someone unintentionally and unknowingly. The wronged person has the same choices you have when you’ve been wronged.

Even if you’re aware that internal pressure builds when you avoid conflict, understand that not everyone feels the same about it. You may get face-to-beat-red-face with a co-worker uncontrollably releasing her built up steam. You may not recall exactly what she is talking about and the same rules apply to being on the receiving end of a confrontation.

Stay calm, even when you can't quite recall the instance the person is confronting you about. Control the energy of the discussion and direct it toward a polite and level-headed discussion of that transgression. If you match their level of pent up energy, you will only feed their negative energy. This is when bad things happen.

Conflict as Opportunity

From the top down, a company must understand the inevitability of conflict. Demonizing differing opinions and silencing detractors only exacerbates pent up feelings. It's clear that many problems can start when management can't see a simple failure in communication as the basis for most workplace conflict, this is when, as Myatt notes "Leaders who don't deal with conflict will eventually watch their good talent walk out the door in search of a healthier and safer work environment."

Leaders must remember that conflict is a natural part of societal interactions. It's unavoidable. Conflict is so common that Rachel Zupek from Career Builder mentioned in a CNN article that "Human resource managers report spending [24 to 60 percent of their time dealing with employee disputes](#)."

Employees must know they have structured avenues available where they feel comfortable confronting a less than favorable situation. David W. Ballard, the head of American Psychological Association's Psychologically Healthy Workplace Program says, "[Conflicts provide the opportunities to better appreciate another perspective](#), clarify your own interests, strengthen bonds and discover new ways forward."

If executives understand the positive potential for conflict through calm and mediated resolution, their employees may ultimately be happier and more productive as a result.

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